

# **The Linguistic Architecture of Capitalism:**

*Industrialization, Colonialism, and the Erasure of the Communal Lexicon*

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[github.com/jennuhh/lexical-erosion](https://github.com/jennuhh/lexical-erosion)

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# The Linguistic Architecture of Capitalism: Industrialization, Colonialism, and the Erasure of the Communal Lexicon

The emergence of the Industrial Revolution in the 18th century served as the primary catalyst for the establishment of capitalism as the dominant global mode of production.<sup>1</sup> This systemic shift did more than reorganize labor and capital; it fundamentally re-engineered the linguistic and cognitive frameworks through which human beings perceive social relations, the environment, and the concept of value.<sup>2</sup> As factory work and a complex division of labor became standardized, the language used to describe human existence underwent a process of "ideational inflation" and "lexical erosion," where communal and relational terms were replaced by an acquisitive, individualistic, and transaction-based vocabulary.<sup>1</sup> This report examines the multi-faceted impact of industrial capitalism on language, analyzing the loss of pre-capitalist vocabularies, the mechanics of linguistic colonization, the cognitive consequences of missing lexical distinctions, and the contemporary movements seeking to reconstruct a non-capitalist economic imagination.

## The Erosion of the Communal Lexicon: From Commoning to Commodity

The transition to industrial capitalism necessitated the dismantling of the "commons"—a system of land tenure and social organization that had persisted in various forms for millennia.<sup>5</sup> This process was not merely physical but linguistic. The Enclosure Acts in England, which reached their peak between 1750 and 1850, transformed land from a shared resource into a "commodity" and revolutionised the concept of private property.<sup>5</sup> In this transition, a rich and highly specific vocabulary for managing shared resources and mutual obligations began to disappear from common usage.

## The Disappearance of Usufructuary Rights

In pre-industrial England, the relationship between people and the land was defined by "rights of common," which allowed "commoners" to use the produce of land they did not own.<sup>8</sup> These rights were not vague abstractions but were categorized with legal and linguistic precision, reflecting a nuanced understanding of ecological limits and community needs.<sup>9</sup>

|                 |                |            |                |
|-----------------|----------------|------------|----------------|
| Right of Common | Technical Term | Functional | Socio-Economic |
|-----------------|----------------|------------|----------------|

|                          |                     | Definition                                                                                  | Significance                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Grazing Rights</b>    | Pasturage / Herbage | The right to graze cattle, horses, sheep, or goats on common land. <sup>8</sup>             | Prevented individual over-accumulation by strictly defining the number and type of animals allowed. <sup>9</sup> |
| <b>Fuel Collection</b>   | Turbary             | The right to dig turf or peat for use as domestic fuel. <sup>8</sup>                        | Ensured energy security for the impoverished without reliance on market-priced coal. <sup>10</sup>               |
| <b>Timber for Repair</b> | Estovers            | The right to take wood (gorse, furze, or fallen branches) for fuel or repairs. <sup>9</sup> | Maintained the infrastructure of the "dominant tenement" through non-monetary resource access. <sup>8</sup>      |
| <b>Pork Production</b>   | Pannage / Mast      | The right to turn pigs into woods to feed on acorns and beechmast. <sup>10</sup>            | Integrated livestock management with forest cycles; pigs removed toxic acorns for other livestock. <sup>9</sup>  |
| <b>Fishing Rights</b>    | Piscary             | The right to take fish from ponds, lakes, or streams. <sup>9</sup>                          | Provided a non-market protein source; strictly for domestic consumption, not commercial profit. <sup>9</sup>     |
| <b>Mineral Access</b>    | Common in the Soil  | The right to take sand, gravel, stone, or coal for domestic use. <sup>9</sup>               | Allowed for the maintenance of local dwellings and paths without entering financial                              |

|  |  |  |                     |
|--|--|--|---------------------|
|  |  |  | debt. <sup>10</sup> |
|--|--|--|---------------------|

The enclosure of the commons effectively rendered these terms obsolete for the majority of the population.<sup>10</sup> As commoners were displaced and forced into urban factory work, the linguistic markers of their previous economic independence—terms such as "appurtenant" (rights attached to land) or "in gross" (rights held personally)—slipped into the domain of archaic legal history.<sup>10</sup> The loss of these words signifies more than a change in farming techniques; it marks the disappearance of a linguistic system that prioritized "use value" and collective stability over "exchange value" and individual growth.<sup>5</sup>

### The Pejorative Shift of Class and Labor Terms

As industrial capitalism took root, the vocabulary used to describe the rural laboring classes underwent a semantic degradation.<sup>14</sup> The term "peasant," originally a neutral description of a pre-industrial agricultural laborer, began to acquire pejorative connotations.<sup>14</sup> In 13th-century Germany, the word "Bauer" (peasant/farmer) began to imply "rustic" or even "robber," a trend mirrored in English by the shift of "villain" (originally a specific class of semi-free serf) to its modern meaning of a wicked person.<sup>14</sup>

This linguistic drift reflects a "class prejudice" where the moral qualities of individuals were equated with their economic status in the burgeoning capitalist order.<sup>2</sup> Terms that once described specific social relations were re-coded to signify inferiority or lack of education.

| Original Term     | Pre-Capitalist Meaning                                                             | Modern/Capitalist Connotation                                       |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Villain / Villein | A semi-free serf or peasant who occupied land in exchange for labor. <sup>14</sup> | A wicked, malicious, or criminal person.                            |
| Boor / Bauer      | A farmer, peasant, or rural laborer. <sup>14</sup>                                 | An unrefined, ill-mannered, or insensitive person.                  |
| Churl             | A free peasant of the lowest rank. <sup>2</sup>                                    | A rude, mean-spirited, or stingy person.                            |
| Commoner          | One with legal rights to access common land. <sup>10</sup>                         | A person of "low breeding" or a non-noble individual. <sup>11</sup> |

This process of semantic pejoration served to alienate the new urban proletariat from their rural history, reinforcing the "standard" language of the governing and capitalist classes as the only legitimate vehicle for progress and success.<sup>3</sup>

# The Rise of Acquisitive Language and Market-Centric Framing

The 200-year transition to high-tech industrial capitalism is quantifiable through the frequency of specific terms in written English. Research utilizing the UCLA Ngram Viewer, which analyzed 1.5 million English-language books, revealed a significant shift from communal and obligatory language toward an "acquisitive" and individualistic vocabulary.<sup>2</sup>

## The Statistical Evidence of Individualist Drift

As societies transitioned from predominantly rural, low-tech communities to urban, high-tech centers, the frequency of words associated with collective duty and mutual aid decreased, while those associated with personal gain and autonomous choice skyrocketed.<sup>3</sup>

| Increasing "Acquisitive" Words | Decreasing "Communal" Words | Causal Context in Industrial Capitalism                                                       |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Get                            | Give                        | Shift from mutual reciprocity to individual accumulation. <sup>2</sup>                        |
| Individual / Self              | Obligated                   | Rise of liberalism and the "moral worth of the individual" over social cohesion. <sup>2</sup> |
| Unique / Choose                | Duty                        | Transformation of laborers into "consumers" with "individual choice". <sup>1</sup>            |
| Efficiency / Deliverables      | Relationship                | The application of factory-style metrics to human interaction. <sup>16</sup>                  |

This trend was briefly interrupted during the more egalitarian Western period between the 1940s and 1970s, but the rise of "remarketized capitalism" and monetarism in the late 20th century under Reagan and Thatcher accelerated the individualistic lexicon once again.<sup>1</sup>

## Raymond Williams and the Evolution of "Keywords"

The Welsh socialist writer Raymond Williams argued that the rise of capitalism hijacked "keywords" of the English language, subtly altering their meanings to support market ideologies.<sup>2</sup> In works such as *Culture and Society* (1958) and *Keywords* (1976), Williams

highlighted how these shifts obscured the social nature of labor.

- **Consumer vs. User:** Williams observed that "user" implies human judgment, need, and purpose—an active engagement with the world.<sup>2</sup> "Consumer," however, focuses on the "stimulated and controlled absorption" of goods provided by an external system. By adopting "consumer" as the standard descriptor for human activity, society focuses on the *market's* convenience rather than the *human's* judgment.<sup>2</sup>
- **Art and Artist:** Historically, "artist" referred to any "skilled person" or craftsman.<sup>2</sup> Under industrial capitalism, it was re-defined as a "special kind of person" working in "imaginative" or "creative" fields, separating "high art" from the "drudgery" of industrial labor.<sup>2</sup>
- **Industry:** Originally meaning "human diligence" or "hard work," the term shifted to describe a "collective body of manufacturing".<sup>2</sup> This transformation objectified human activity into a measurable sector of the economy.

The pervasive use of financial and management metaphors has since permeated everyday life. We speak of "leveraging" relationships, "investing" in friendships, and meeting "deliverables" in our personal lives.<sup>4</sup> This "financialization" of language implies that all human experience can be translated into the logic of money and transaction.<sup>4</sup>

## Linguistic Colonization: Imposing the Transactional Frame

Linguistic colonization occurs when a dominant power imposes its language—and the ideologies embedded within it—on a subordinated group.<sup>19</sup> In the context of global capitalism, this has involved the systematic suppression of Indigenous languages and the imposition of a transaction-based framing that favors Western economic interests.<sup>19</sup>

### The Mechanics of "Colonialinguualism"

Scholars use the term "Colonialinguualism" to describe how colonial languages like English carry imperial legacies that prioritize neoliberal worldviews.<sup>21</sup> English is often commodified as a "resource" for "upward mobility," forcing speakers of other languages to adopt its transactional framing to participate in the global economy.<sup>16</sup>

The colonization of Africa, Indochina, and Polynesia yielded natural resources for European powers and created vast new populations of "consumers".<sup>1</sup> Missionaries and colonial administrators often found it necessary to learn Indigenous languages to proselytize or manage labor, but in doing so, they frequently "re-translated" local concepts into Christian or capitalist frameworks.<sup>22</sup> For example, Indigenous concepts of land stewardship were often interpreted by colonizers as "surrender" or "sale" in treaties, as the notion of permanent land ownership did not exist in many Indigenous worldviews.<sup>23</sup>

## Resistance and Resilience: Case Studies in South America

While hundreds of Indigenous languages have been lost, some have shown remarkable resilience, preserving linguistic structures that resist capitalist objectification.<sup>25</sup>

- **Guaraní (Paraguay):** Guaraní is the only Indigenous language in the Americas that has resisted assimilation into Spanish or Portuguese across an entire nation.<sup>26</sup> Despite being banned under the dictatorship of Alfredo Stroessner, it survived in rural homes and is now an official language.<sup>26</sup> Guaraní emphasizes simplicity and meaningful interaction over "extravagant words".<sup>25</sup> Its resilience is rooted in its role as a "language of resistance," passed down by women after the devastating Triple Alliance War, which killed two-thirds of the population.<sup>26</sup>
- **Quechua (The Andes):** Quechua maintains a deep vocabulary for non-transactional exchange and medical knowledge.<sup>27</sup> Central to Quechua culture is the concept of **Ayni**, a principle of reciprocity that organizes community work.<sup>27</sup> Unlike the capitalist "zero-sum" game, **Ayni** assumes that mutual aid is a "labor tribute" that sustains the community over generations.<sup>11</sup>

## The Loss of Animacy and the Objectification of the Living World

A critical aspect of capitalist linguistic colonization is the "numbing" effect of Western grammar on the human relationship with the environment.<sup>29</sup> Robin Wall Kimmerer argues that the English language facilitates the exploitation of nature through its "grammar of animacy," or rather, the lack thereof.<sup>29</sup>

### The Human-Centered Hierarchy of English

In English, nearly all non-human entities—plants, animals, rivers, and mountains—are referred to as "it".<sup>29</sup> This linguistic choice objectifies the living world, stripping it of agency and moral standing.<sup>29</sup> Kimmerer contrasts this with her native Potawatomi, where verbs and pronouns reflect the aliveness of the world.

| Concept        | English Framing (Objectified)                                         | Potawatomi Framing (Animate)                                                 |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Nature as Noun | "The bay" is a static place; a noun defining an object. <sup>31</sup> | "To be a bay"—the water is <i>happening</i> as a living being. <sup>31</sup> |
| Pronoun Choice | "It" (used for a river, a tree,                                       | "Ki" (singular) or "Kin"                                                     |

|                       |                                                                                 |                                                                                     |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                       | or a bulldozer). <sup>29</sup>                                                  | (plural) for earth-beings. <sup>29</sup>                                            |
| <b>Ethical Impact</b> | It is easier to cut down an "it" (a thing) than a "ki" (a being). <sup>30</sup> | Moral responsibility and gratitude are required for all interactions. <sup>30</sup> |
| <b>Worldview</b>      | Human exceptionalism; detachment from the commonwealth of life. <sup>29</sup>   | Interconnectedness; all entities are "peoples" with sovereign rights. <sup>32</sup> |

This "human-centered" worldview in English is a "subtractive" force that allows for the commodification of nature as a mere "resource".<sup>21</sup> By reducing the world to "things" for our use, capitalism removes the linguistic barriers to ecological destruction.<sup>29</sup>

## Cognitive Impact: Does Missing Vocabulary Limit Economic Imagination?

The relationship between language and thought is a cornerstone of the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, which suggests that the structures of our native language shape our perceptions of reality.<sup>33</sup> In the context of economics, this hypothesis explores whether the lack of non-capitalist vocabulary limits our ability to imagine alternative systems.<sup>4</sup>

### Linguistic Determinism vs. Linguistic Relativity

- **Strong Form (Determinism):** Posits that if a language lacks a word for a concept, the speaker cannot understand that concept.<sup>33</sup> Most modern linguists reject this extreme view, noting that human beings are capable of conceptualizing what they cannot name.<sup>35</sup>
- **Weak Form (Relativity):** Asserts that language *influences* thought, behavior, and the speed of categorization.<sup>33</sup> This is supported by studies on color perception and spatial reasoning.<sup>38</sup>

In economics, the weak form is particularly relevant. Yale economist Keith Chen's research suggested that speakers of languages with a clear grammatical future tense (like English) may feel more "distanced" from the future, leading to higher rates of debt and poor financial planning compared to speakers of "futureless" languages (like Mandarin or German) who view the future and present as linguistically integrated.<sup>33</sup>

### Language as a Constraint on Economic Imagination

Harold James argues that our economic world is constrained by the "limits of our language".<sup>4</sup> When terms like "capitalism" or "socialism" become "gigantic snowballs" that cover too much ground, they lose their precision as analytical tools.<sup>4</sup> This "ideational inflation" forces us into binary choices—globalization vs. nation-state, market vs. state—that prevent the

conceptualization of hybrid or emerging realities like the "neural commons" or "commoning".<sup>4</sup>

Furthermore, Whorf observed that English grammar forces a subject-predicate division that may not exist in nature.<sup>41</sup> For example, the Hopi language describes events as "manifest" or "unmanifest" rather than through past/present/future tenses, allowing for a more relational understanding of time.<sup>35</sup> By restricting our thinking to the "plain English" of market transactions, we may lose the power to perceive "interconnected aliveness" that is necessary for sustainability.<sup>31</sup>

## Modern Gaps: Untranslatable States and Relational Phenomena

English, despite its extensive vocabulary for finance and industry, often lacks concise terms for deep relational, emotional, and non-monetary experiences.<sup>43</sup> These "lexical gaps" (or lacunae) require lengthy explanations and suggest a different "cultural weighting" in English-speaking societies.<sup>44</sup>

### Relational and Communal Lacunae

| Untranslatable Term | Source Language | Conceptual Meaning in English                                                                       | Significance in Post-Capitalist Thought                                                   |
|---------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ubuntu              | Zulu / Xhosa    | "I am because we are"; personhood is co-bestowed by the collective. <sup>46</sup>                   | Rejects individualist "Homo Economicus" in favor of intersubjectivity. <sup>40</sup>      |
| Fargin              | Yiddish         | The ungrudging joy felt for another's success; the opposite of <i>Schadenfreude</i> . <sup>44</sup> | Essential for non-competitive, cooperative economic models. <sup>44</sup>                 |
| Toska               | Russian         | A deep, cause-less spiritual anguish or a sick pining of the soul. <sup>44</sup>                    | Describes a malaise that modern "boredom" or "depression" fails to capture. <sup>44</sup> |

|                  |            |                                                                                  |                                                                                            |
|------------------|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ailyak</b>    | Bulgarian  | The art of doing things slowly and savoring the process of life. <sup>44</sup>   | A direct linguistic act of resistance against industrial "efficiency". <sup>16</sup>       |
| <b>Saudade</b>   | Portuguese | A melancholic longing for something absent or that never existed. <sup>43</sup>  | Captures the emotional complexity of communal loss and displacement. <sup>43</sup>         |
| <b>Wabi-sabi</b> | Japanese   | Appreciation of the beauty in imperfection, transience, and decay. <sup>45</sup> | Opposes the market's demand for standardized, perfect, and disposable goods. <sup>45</sup> |

The presence of these words in other languages—and their absence in English—indicates areas where communities have developed "dense, conventionalized patterns for evaluating experience" that fall outside the market's reach.<sup>45</sup> When a concept is central to a community's "ritual life or moral judgment," it tends to be lexicalized; the fact that English lacks these words suggests a relative devaluation of these states in a capitalist context.<sup>45</sup>

## Indigenous Concepts of Non-Transactional Exchange

Pre-capitalist and Indigenous societies often utilized frameworks of "everyday communism," where the allocation of tasks was based on ability and the provision of needs occurred without formal accounting.<sup>48</sup> This "radical incalculability" of social bonds was expressed through specific economic terminologies.

- **Ubuntu (Southern Africa):** This philosophy emphasizes that "human individuality is a necessary but not sufficient" condition for personhood.<sup>47</sup> It encompasses spiritual interdependence and respect for the ecosystem, including totemic animals and ancestors.<sup>50</sup>
- **Mink'a / Minka (The Andes):** A tradition of "asking for help by promising something"—usually voluntary collective labor for social utility, such as building canals or community kitchens.<sup>27</sup> It is a "cash-free form of local taxation" that ensures the care of orphans, the elderly, and the disabled.<sup>27</sup>
- **Harambee (East Africa):** Meaning "all pull together," it serves as a mechanism for communal fund-raising and resource mobilization for local development.<sup>51</sup>
- **Ujamaa (Tanzania):** A philosophy of "extended family" or "brotherhood," used as the basis for socialist development policies in the post-colonial era.<sup>18</sup>

These concepts do not merely describe "altruism"; they describe a "moral economy" where the creation and recreation of social bonds take primacy over the accumulation of capital.<sup>40</sup>

## Vocabulary Reconstruction: Neologisms and Cognitive Activism

In response to the "monoculture of the mind" produced by global capitalism, activists and scholars are engaged in "vocabulary reconstruction"—the creation of new words to fill lexical gaps and expand economic imagination.<sup>39</sup>

### The Glossary of Cognitive Activism

The *Glossary of Cognitive Activism* is an "iterative activist dictionary" containing over 330 words designed to navigate the "neural-digital despotism" of modern capitalism.<sup>39</sup> It provides intellectual tools to resist the "AI-generated monoculture" and promotes "neurodiverse ways of thinking" as essential for liberation.<sup>39</sup>

- **Cognitariat:** Refers to the class of mental laborers whose "neural plasticity" is exploited by digital platforms.<sup>39</sup>
- **Neural Commons:** The shared mental landscape that must be reclaimed for "political, cultural, and ecologic sculpting".<sup>39</sup>

### Solarpunk and the Language of Hope

Solarpunk is an aesthetic and activist movement that seeks to answer the question: "What does a sustainable and just civilization look like?".<sup>52</sup> It rejects the "dystopian pessimism" of Cyberpunk, which portrays high-tech societies with a low quality of life and no community.<sup>52</sup> Solarpunk utilizes a vocabulary of "regeneration," "abundance of the commons," and "ecocentric technology" to challenge the "artificial scarcity" imposed by capitalist markets.<sup>52</sup>

### Neologism as Disruption

Neologisms serve as indicators of cultural shifts and can influence public awareness by "naming the new".<sup>53</sup> During the Industrial Revolution, words like "broadcasting" were re-purposed from the agricultural practice of "scattering seeds" to describe the spread of information via radio.<sup>53</sup> Today, creative neologisms such as "tax avoision" or "anthropause" (the global slowdown of human activity during COVID-19) highlight systemic cracks and new ecological realities.<sup>44</sup>

Walter Redfern described neologism as the "linguistic equivalent of capitalism" because it capitalizes on resources to create new value, but he noted a key difference: "language cancels all debts".<sup>55</sup> There is no interest rate on loan words, and no police can protect a word's "property," making neologism a powerful tool for the "disruption of the liberal economic order".<sup>55</sup>

# Conclusion: Toward an Intellectual Hygiene of Economic Life

The analysis indicates that industrial capitalism and its colonial expansions have systematically pruned the human lexicon, favoring a narrow set of transactional and individualistic terms at the expense of communal, relational, and animate worldviews.<sup>3</sup> The statistical decline of words like "give" and "obliged," combined with the rise of the objectifying pronoun "it," suggests a profound narrowing of human moral and ecological consideration.<sup>3</sup>

However, the resilience of languages like Guaraní and the emergence of "cognitive activism" demonstrate that this linguistic era is not a final state.<sup>26</sup> To overcome the limits of our current economic imagination, a process of "intellectual decluttering" is required—a fundamental rethinking of terms like "the economy," "consumer," and "industry" to move beyond the binary constraints of the industrial past.<sup>4</sup> By integrating pre-capitalist concepts like **Ubuntu** and **Ayni** into modern discourse, and by fostering the "grammar of animacy," society may begin to reconstruct a language that recognizes "interconnected aliveness" as the primary value of human and teresapien existence.<sup>31</sup> The reunion of language with economy is not merely a linguistic task; it is the prerequisite for the cosmic society of the future.<sup>56</sup>

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